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INTERVIEW

« With the changing nature of wickets, those days when you could bowl slower on turning tracks to deceive the batter are behind us »

RASHID KHAN

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Rashid Khan has been one of the star performers in the Indian Premier League (IPL) for eight years. But the early stages of the 2025 edition were tough for the Afghan spin ace.

Returning from a hamstring injury, he struggled in his first few outings for Gujarat Titans — conceding runs and lacking impact. As the tournament wore on, though, he found his rhythm. With seven wickets so far, he admits poor control over line and length cost him early on. In an exclusive chat with *Sportstar*, Rashid talks spin, the challenges of this season's pitches, and the road ahead.

You had a tough start to the tournament. How did you deal with that phase, especially coming back from injury?

The pitches haven't been very helpful for spinners, but even then, I felt I was off with my line and length

in the first few games. Earlier, when the surface offered a bit of turn, batters still struggled to find boundaries even if you missed your spot slightly. But that's not the case now. If you bowl a loose delivery, it almost always goes for four. This season, you have to be spot on with your areas. In those early matches, I gave away too many runs and didn't pick up many wickets because I wasn't landing the ball where I should have.

During that period, did you focus on any specific areas to get back into rhythm?

I knew I had to go back to basics — stick to the line and length I've trusted for the last nine or ten years and just back myself. As a cricketer, there are times when things don't go your way, but it's important not to overthink. The more cluttered your mind gets, the harder it becomes to find a way out.

I focused on staying clear about

what I needed to do. With experience, you realise that even when you give 100 per cent, results might not follow immediately. Sometimes a full toss gets you a wicket. Other times, you bowl the perfect delivery and still get hit for four. That's the nature of the game — you have to accept it and keep moving forward.

With T20 cricket increasingly favouring batters, how does a spinner adapt to the format?

You don't need to overthink it. For a spinner, the key is to focus on length — consistently hitting that good-length area. When there's no help from the pitch, your options are limited. Seamers can go for slow bouncers or wide yorkers, but as a spinner, you can't rely on those. You have to back your strengths, stick to your plans, and execute them well.

Variations like the wrong'un or the flipper should be introduced gradually, once you're settled. You